

player that will appeal to the ladies. It is the smallest, and has that subtle feel of femininity.

The user interface (UI) on all these players was more or less the same, and we're not complaining. We liked the UIs of the Samsung and the Creative players.

The UMAX and Orite players were painful to use—their UIs left a lot to be desired, and their buttons were tiny and cumbersome.

The iPod Shuffle and iRiver N10 and iFP-799 players could only be accessed using their bundled software—iTunes for the iPod and iRiver Music Manager for the iRiver duo. Such functionality simply mars the experience of using a portable music player, since you may not have the software installed on every system you want to transfer music from. While this acts as a deterrent for illegal copying of music, it is also a handicap when trying to use the device for portable storage, unless you have the requisite software handy all the time.

Overall, we had quite a lot of players with features that in some cases were utilitarian but in some, absurd. And, how did these players perform against each other? That is what we talk about, next.

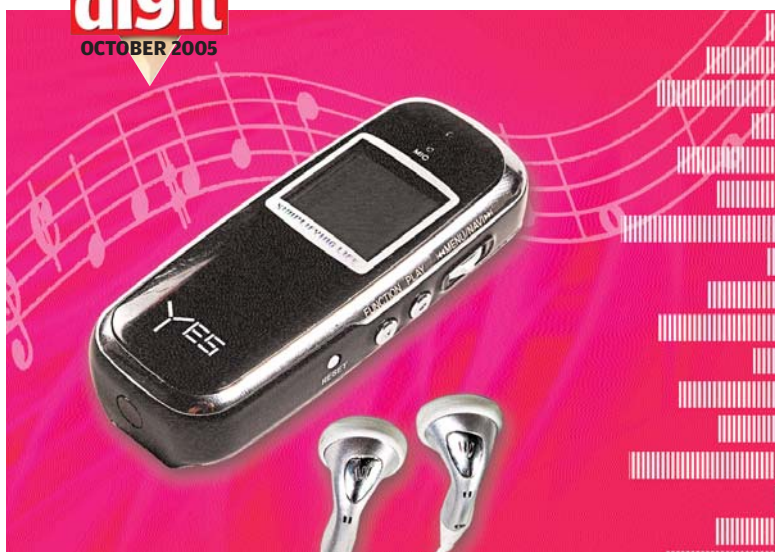
Performance

The performance department is the place where we pit the best against the best. This test was broken up into Audio Quality, Data Transfer and Battery Life tests.

Audio Quality

In terms of performance, there were three distinct groups—Creative, Samsung and iRiver.

The Apple iPod stood out all by itself, but put on an absolutely stunning performance in terms of audio quality. Going by audio performance, the Creative players were worth the money that they retailed at. The earphones on these players complement the players well. They are perfectly balanced in terms of the tone, bass and treble. Of course, pushing the volume envelope does produce a fair amount of jarring, but if you started listening to music at



The YES YMP-910 has a TV remote feature

that high decibel levels, say goodbye to your ear drums!

The iRiver trio were the best when it came to audio quality. When listening to music, you can set your own favourite preset or custom equaliser setting that the kind of music you listen to sounds best on. Technologies such as SRS WOW enhance the whole experience of listening to music.

The SRS WOW implementation in these players is extremely good and the bass couldn't get punchier on any other player except the iRivers.

SRS WOW enhancement was sorely missing on the Samsung YP-T8, which would definitely add to the audio quality of the player. The YES YMP-910 player also put up a good show in the audio performance department.

The SAFA trio was another set of players that put up a good performance. These players also had external speakers, but the speakers are useless in noisy environments. The earphones bundled with these players were of good quality and complemented the players.

FM reception was very good on the Samsung and Creative players, while it was just okay on the iRiver players. For the others, MSI Megastick was very good for FM reception, but voice recording was not up to the mark.

The SAFA and Bravish had mediocre FM reception, but the voice recording was good. The rest of the players didn't really have anything outstanding to talk about.

Data Transfer

When it came to data transfer speeds, no one could beat the Samsung YP-T8. We transferred almost 100 MB worth of data to this player in 13 seconds, the fastest in the whole comparison.

The second in terms of the fastest data transfer was its compatriot, the YP-T7 with 14 seconds. Though sluggish, data transfer speeds on the iRivers were faster than some of the other players in this comparison test.

The worst of the lot was the SAFA M520F that took a whopping 192 seconds to transfer 100 MB of data.



The iRiver T30 has excellent audio quality